Scabies

Treat the person and close contacts together to prevent reinfestation

ABOUT THIS TOPIC

Scabies is caused by tiny mites and can cause intense itching, often worse at night, and a bumpy rash. It spreads mainly through prolonged skin-to-skin contact. It is not a sign of poor hygiene.

Everyday care and treatment

- Arrange assessment with a health professional. Scabies requires prescription treatment; ordinary anti-itch products do not kill mites.
- Use the prescribed scabies medicine exactly as directed. Some treatments need a repeat application; follow the specific instructions given.
- Close household and intimate contacts may need treatment at the same time, even if they do not yet itch.
- Wash recently used clothes, towels, and bedding in hot water and dry on a hot cycle. Items that cannot be washed can be sealed in a bag for several days, following local clinical advice.

WHEN TO GET HELP

Seek follow-up if itching or new burrows continue after treatment, if the skin becomes infected, or if an infant or a person with a weakened immune system may be affected. Itching can continue for a few weeks after successful treatment; ask a clinician if unsure.

Sources for further reading

US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention - Scabies treatment - https://www.cdc.gov/scabies/treatment/index.html

Reviewed for this educational handout: October 2026. Recommendations can change and depend on local guidance, age, pregnancy, other health conditions, and medicines. This handout is not a diagnosis or prescription.